

MOVING IMAGE

# Dreaming in collections

Art happens in different forms. I am interested in changing forms. I am interested in machine learning.

*When I woke up for you today, I arrived at yesterday.  
Dreaming in collections, forgetting who I am.*

MY WRITING

CEMETERY DATASET · WGAN  
THE COLLECTED, A CHARACTER

## Cemeteries as museums

Cemeteries are museums that contain humans as datasets. Merging art collections (many containing figures that are dead) allow me to learn stories, techniques, fictions, historical and social elements.

The video is mainly made from my own cemetery images, and from WGAN training with them. The sound is made from the green generated video's still.

The gravestones are playing a game like chess with their stone. Gravestones changing their places, they exchange places and the ground shake like an earthquake with their movement. Stones slowly come to life and walks among the gravestones. The scene remains unchanged: an overgrown, abandoned cemetery with dense green foliage and old tombstones. The camera is still. The moves subtly and naturally, heavy steps. Slightly eerie atmosphere, cinematic realism.

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THE CHARACTER

## The collected

The collected is the 3D resin print, made out of a model trained with sculpture pictures of the collection. It is a sculpture from an AI collection, living in the latent space. In the prompts it is given things to do:

The collected is a sculpture from an ai collection, living in the latent space. It is having calm discussions with other artworks in the collection in this image. Keep the aesthetics.

The collected is a sculpture from an ai collection, it is trying to swim in the sea with other artworks in the collection in this image. The sea becomes wavy and the sculpture is struggling.

This figure is very melancholic and crying in this peculiar cemetery. She takes her arms outside the duvet and wipes her tears.

Sculptural forms as repeated representations. Exploring actions. AI as an intermediary.

## Life, death, and an algorithmic irony

The video has a deep connection to having a life, and death is the unchangeable fact of it. It is an algorithmic irony on being a human and on being an artwork in a collection. It is a fictional latent space journey, inspired by cyberspace narratives.

A question: how would an AI collection look like, or what does it tell us possibly? What medium is a human being? What medium is a tree full of green leaves? What medium is time? What does it mean to be made of?

I am the not-founder of this project. Are humans too damaged to think? Is that why AI and the generated elements feel promethean, thought-provoking?

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Changing forms, artificial intelligence, imitation, curiousness, love, artwork's identity, exploring deeper artistic possibilities in image making using artworks.

Zylinska writes that AI dreams up the human outside the human, and that raising existential questions about creativity in the face of the machine keeps alive an older picture of the human as a system with just enough data to process for meaning to appear. The cemetery is where that picture runs out. The dead are already a dataset, the collection is already an afterlife, and the model is the only thing in the room still generating.

Zylinska, J., 2020. *AI Art: Machine Visions and Warped Dreams*. London: Open Humanities Press.

## References for the moving image

Works that share the method: an archive re-edited until it speaks, a machine given a gaze, a fiction built as a place you can enter.

### Jean-Luc Godard

Le Livre d'image (The Image Book), 2018

Godard's final essay film is assembled almost entirely from existing material — film excerpts, television archives, paintings, fragments of text and music — pulled from a vast image archive including his own earlier films. He degrades and reframes what he takes, sacrificing fidelity to colour saturation, flicker and distortion, so that the fragments contradict and attack each other rather than settle into a history.

The connection: an archive is not a source here, it is a material. The Image Book is a collection editing itself, which is the operation the trained model performs on the cemetery images.

### Harun Farocki

Parallel I-IV, 2012-14;  
Eye/Machine, 2001-03

Parallel traces computer-generated worlds from early two-dimensional schematics to photorealism, examining how these worlds render nature, how they set their boundaries, what their physics allow, and how characters relate to each other inside them. Farocki intercuts footage of animators at work, so the labour behind the simulation stays visible. Eye/Machine deals with images made by machines for machines rather than for people.

The connection: Farocki asks what happens when an image has no bond to anything real. A cemetery generated by a WGAN from photographs of real graves sits exactly on that line.

### Nye Thompson

Backdoored, 2016-18; The Seeker, ongoing

Backdoored systematically collected screenshots from unsecured surveillance cameras worldwide — images whose content lies as much in how they were made as in what they show. The Seeker developed out of this: a machine entity that travels the world through those cameras and uses image recognition to describe what it sees, later given physical avatars with camera eyes and whispering synthesised voices.

The connection: Thompson builds a character out of a dataset and lets it speak. The collected is the same manoeuvre in sculpture — a model's output given a name, a body and something to do.

### Christian Mio Loclair

Narciss

An artificial intelligence built for one purpose only: to investigate itself. It is presented at once as an artwork, a model of synthetic self-awareness, and a fictional character narrating its own autobiography.

The connection: the clearest precedent for treating a model as a character rather than a tool, and for letting it be melancholic about its own condition.

## Sterling Crispin

Data-masks, 2013–15

Masks generated by working backwards through facial detection and recognition algorithms, then 3D printed — physical objects whose shape is dictated by what a machine considers a face to be.

The connection: an object printed straight out of a model's interior, which is what the resin print is. Crispin's masks show the machine's idea of a person; the collected shows the machine's idea of a sculpture.

## Tai Shani

Dark Continent / DC:  
Semiramis, 2014–

An episodic project of films, performances, installations and experimental texts building an allegorical city of women, drawn from a medieval source in which fact, fiction and myth are already entangled. Each chapter follows one character. The installations work as places the fiction can be entered rather than as backdrops.

The connection: how to hold a fictional world together across sculpture, text and video without any of them becoming illustration of the others.

## Cyberspace narratives

Latent space as a place

The convention that a computational space can be travelled through, inhabited and survived comes out of cyberpunk fiction, where the network is described as a landscape with weather, distance and danger. Latent space inherits the same grammar: we say a model moves through it, wanders, gets lost.

The connection: the video takes that grammar literally. The collected is not a rendering of a sculpture — it is a character on a journey through a space that only exists as coordinates.

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### ALSO LOOKING AT

Matt Saunders; Jonathan Fly; Guillaume Slizewicz, Decors; Meriem Bennani; Bassam Issa; Nina Hartmann; Simon Denny, Machine Paintings; Feral File, Ex Nihilo; Nye Thompson's contemporaries collected at [mlart.co](http://mlart.co) and [movingimageartists.co.uk](http://movingimageartists.co.uk); Bogna Konior on machine thought; transmediale, The Finiteness of Algorithms.

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